

Chapter 89-2

Liang Shi had just finished changing when, before she could even pull back the curtain, she heard a girl crying in the adjacent space, sobbing while complaining aggrievedly: "Why is it so dirty here? Wuwuwu, I don't want to change clothes here. I can pay money—can you give me a better place? Wuwu, can't I just build them a changing room? What did I do wrong to deserve this kind of suffering?"

Someone beside her was coaxing her: "My little ancestor¹, weren't you the one who said you wanted to come act? Everyone told you not to come, and now that you're here, you're complaining non-stop."

"I... wuwuwu... I just wanted to be in the same frame as Sister Shuyan. Who knew the filming environment would be this bad?" The girl continued crying.

Liang Shi listened from the side and understood—this was a die-hard fan of Yang Shuyan.

Chasing her idol to the point of becoming an actress herself.

That was quite impressive, actually.

Though she didn't know if this person had invested money to join the production or was here incognito.

The conversation next door continued. Although that pretentious little princess was complaining, she still changed her clothes in that dirty place.

Crying while doing it—it was quite amusing to listen to.

Liang Shi came out after changing and put her clothes into a bag she had prepared in advance. This action made the staff member assigned to her pause in surprise. "Have you filmed before?"

Liang Shi answered: "Just for half a day."

For this world, it was indeed only half a day.

That was also the information the staff member had. The director had specifically told her that this was a newcomer and to pay extra attention, but she hadn't expected Liang Shi's behavior to be nothing like someone who had only filmed for half a day.

After arriving at the set, she didn't look around curiously like a newcomer, wasn't nervous, and even brought her own storage bag to pack away her clothes.

These were all little bits of experience that came from spending a long time with production crews. Especially since she didn't have an assistant, these things were even more commendable.

"That's pretty good." The staff member said calmly.

Then she told Liang Shi to put her clothes in the locker. When she came back around, Liang Shi saw the little princess from next door. Based on her appearance, she should be her CP² in the drama—barely qualifying as the fifth female lead.

The other party didn't have many scenes, basically revolving around her character. She fell in love with a villain and attempted to reform the antagonist with her innocent personality. The villain actually did feel something for her during their time together but firmly pushed her away, so their storyline was a BE³.

It had to be said, the director had quite an eye for casting.

This girl probably wasn't very good at acting, but her real-life image matched the character in the drama very well. It wouldn't be difficult for her to perform—as long as she believed in the story, her acting would be lively.

Seeing her looking at that girl, the staff member took the initiative to introduce: "She's Yan Xi, playing Wu Luxi in the drama. She's also an actress who has a lot of scenes with you. You can go say hello to her later. Building some rapport between you two will make filming feel more natural."

Liang Shi nodded: "Thank you."

The subsequent procedures were similar to what Liang Shi had experienced before—meeting the director, then mingling in the crowd, waiting for the incense offering, ribbon cutting, receiving red envelopes⁴, and group photos.

The girl named Yan Xi stood next to her during the photo because they had many scenes together.

After the photos were done, she went to complain to her agent again, "Why isn't Sister Shuyan here? Isn't she going to appear in this drama? But I only saw Zhao Ying. I'm so angry."

"Miss Yang was only doing a friendship cameo from the start. She definitely wouldn't appear at the opening ceremony." The agent advised, "My little ancestor, please calm down a bit. This isn't like home. If you don't want to be here, we can withdraw at any time."

"No." Yan Xi gripped her mineral water bottle, her words firm: "I must stand in the same position as Sister Shuyan and let her know I'm ten thousand times better than that annoying Zhao Ying!"

Oh ho.

So she was here to poach someone?

Liang Shi didn't have a habit of eavesdropping. It was just that she was hiding in the shade, and before long, the little princess and her agent came over.

The two of them talked without checking if there was anyone around, not even trying to be discreet, openly badmouthing someone.

Liang Shi couldn't exactly cover her ears just to avoid hearing their gossip.

Just as she was about to leave, Zhao Ying came over and handed her a bottle of water. "What's up? Came here to find some peace and quiet?"

Liang Shi smiled and greeted her: "Sister Ying."

When she turned to look at those two people, she found they had left at some point.

Zhao Ying shook her head to herself: "After all this time, I still find them noisy."

Liang Shi smiled: "Then come hide here for some peace and quiet with me."

"Sure." Zhao Ying took a sip of water and stood there with her, looking at the scenery for a while.

There wasn't much to see, really. Late autumn had arrived, autumn leaves were falling, a layer of golden leaves covered the ground, and the trees were becoming bare. Apart from the distant mountains with their overlapping peaks in the suburbs and the azure sky at the far horizon that could lift one's spirits a little, everything else was ordinary.

However, after Zhao Ying finished drinking her water, she asked leisurely: "What did you just overhear?"

Liang Shi: "..."

"Huh?" Liang Shi played dumb.

"Come on, stop pretending." Zhao Ying said: "I didn't come over just now, but I saw you smiling while listening. What did you hear?"

Liang Shi awkwardly touched the tip of her nose.

Zhao Ying spoke first: "The one acting opposite you is Yang Shuyan's..."

She paused, clicked her tongue, and said, "Little childhood sweetheart."

Liang Shi: "?"

This was truly explosive gossip.

Liang Shi had thought it was a die-hard fan who had chased her idol to the production to act, but it turned out to be a real little princess.

"Then..." Liang Shi tentatively asked: "Sister Ying, you and Yang Shuyan..."

Zhao Ying raised an eyebrow: "Want to know?"

Liang Shi: "..."

Looking at Zhao Ying's somewhat dangerous smile, Liang Shi suddenly felt that not knowing was also fine.

But Zhao Ying said straightforwardly: "Exchange secrets."

Liang Shi: "..."

Two seconds later, she unhesitatingly told Zhao Ying what she had just heard, then patted Zhao Ying on the shoulder. "Sister Ying, good luck!"

Her tone was teasing. Zhao Ying glanced at her. "Oh please, she's just a little girl."

The underlying meaning Liang Shi heard was—just a little girl, not worth my effort.

And Zhao Ying said matter-of-factly: "Of course I need to show her what this big sister's charm is like—something she couldn't catch up to even if she tried for eighty years."

Liang Shi: "...?"

Liang Shi was amused by Zhao Ying. "Sister Ying is impressive."

"Stop flattering me." Zhao Ying said: "From now on at the set, I'll pretend not to know you, okay?"

Liang Shi: "Hm?"

Zhao Ying shrugged. "That little girl's family is quite rich. If she gets angry and throws money at the production, and gets you blacklisted⁵ along the way, we'd have to make a fuss, and that would be troublesome."

Liang Shi: "...Alright."

And Liang Shi's sneaky gaze turned toward Zhao Ying.

Zhao Ying unhurriedly took a sip of water. Knowing what Liang Shi wanted to gossip about, after finishing that sip, she tossed the bottle in her hand into the trash can across from them.

The empty water bottle drew a perfect arc through the air. Zhao Ying put both hands in her trench coat pockets, her tone rising, carrying a few parts arrogance and recklessness, as she said airily: "Friends with benefits—"

She drew out the words for a few seconds before curling her lips into a smile. "A relationship that hasn't been made official yet."

Liang Shi: "..."

Do your fans know about this?

Footnotes:

¹ **My little ancestor (祖宗):** A Chinese term of endearment (though sometimes exasperated) used for someone who is being difficult or demanding, often a spoiled child or young person. It literally means "ancestor" but is used sarcastically to suggest the person is being treated like royalty.

² **CP:** Short for "coupling" or "couple pairing," a term borrowed from fan culture referring to a romantic pairing between characters in a story.

³ **BE:** Short for "Bad Ending," a term used in Chinese web novel and fan communities to indicate a storyline that ends tragically or without the couple getting together, as opposed to "HE" (Happy Ending).

⁴ **Red envelopes (紅包):** Traditional Chinese gifts of money in red packets, given during celebrations. In the entertainment industry, it's customary to give red envelopes to cast and crew during opening ceremonies for good luck.

⁵ **Blacklisted (雪藏):** Literally "hidden in snow," this term in the Chinese entertainment industry refers to when a company or powerful person deliberately suppresses an artist's career opportunities, essentially putting them "on ice."